of social reform. "The demand is a direct attack on OBCs and marginalised communities," says Vanni Arasu, deputy general secretary of the Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi. "The department was created to dismantle Brahminical monopoly over temples. A reversal will bring back exclusion."

Another resolution urged Hindu consolidation as a voting bloc. A third encouraged the collective chanting of 19th-century Tamil devotional hymn 'Kandha Sashti Kavasam', casting it as a tool for religious unity, though implicitly Hindu-only.

The choice of Madurai as the site for this event was strategic. Not just a temple city, it is also a hub of Dravidian political identity. In recent months, it has emerged as a stage for political theatre—hosting actor Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) rally, an AIADMK conference, a DMK roadshow helmed by Chief Minister M.K. Stalin and a visit by Union home minister Amit Shah.

Just outside the city lies Thiruparankundram, where one of Murugan's six abodes stands alongside an old Sufi dargah and ancient Jain caves. Hindu Munnani has labelled the area as "encroached" by other faiths, inflaming local tensions. One resolution called for lighting the 'Karthigai Deepam'—associated with Murugan—atop the hill; another backed protecting the sacred hills from "non-Hindu" practices.

Even before the event was held, civil society groups, including the Madurai Religious Harmony Federation, raised objections, warning of communal polarisation. They now plan to hold a 'People's Unity Conference' on June 29 to promote interfaith harmony.

Lord Murugan's symbolic importance is not new in TN. Last year, the DMK government organised a global conference on Murugan to showcase him as a secular cultural icon of the Tamil diaspora. The BJP's effort is explicitly majoritarian, hoping to turn the folk deity into a unifying religious figurehead like Ram. In this battle of narratives, Madurai's become both symbol and stage. ■

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